

DAD'S CODE

Present, *Not* Perfect

A Rebuilt Dad's Field Guide to
Showing Up

Jamie Wigg

Dad's Code

- 6 chapters
- 6 things to try today
- ≈ 15 min read

Present, not perfect.

Before we start

Present, Not Perfect · © Jamie Wigg / Dad's Code.
For my kids — and the dad I'm still becoming.

“Being present beats being perfect.”

DAD'S CODE

A note on support

This is one dad's lived experience, not medical advice. If you're struggling, please reach out — you're not weak for needing help. In Australia: **Lifeline 13 11 14**, **Beyond Blue 1300 22 4636**. If you're in immediate danger, call **000**.

How to read this

Short on purpose. Each chapter is a story, the core idea (“The Code”), a quick note on the research behind it, and **one thing to try today**. You don't need to read it in order. You don't need to finish it tonight. You just need to start.

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Introduction

The Dad I Thought I Had to Be

I grew up with a father whose love arrived as money, not presence. At ten, I made a silent vow: if I ever have kids, I'll be there.

It took me decades — and a lot of falling down — to learn that “being there” was never about being perfect. I chased the perfect-dad image for years and it made me *worse*: tense, distant, performing instead of connecting.

This little book is the field guide I wish someone had handed me. It's blunt, it's short, and it works. Six chapters. Six small shifts. Let's go.

The Myth of the Perfect Dad

THE STORY

For years I measured myself against a dad who doesn't exist — calm always, right always, never tired. Chasing him, I was so busy performing that I stopped actually *connecting* with my kids.

— THE CODE

The perfect-dad image is a trap. Chasing it makes you *less* present, because you're managing your image instead of being with your child.

THE RESEARCH, LIGHTLY Winnicott's idea of the **“good-enough” parent** — kids don't need perfect parents, they need consistent, warm, good-enough ones. Consistency beats perfection every time.

● ONE THING TODAY

Write down one “perfect dad” standard you're going to drop this week. Say it out loud: “I'm letting that one go.”

What “Present” Actually Means

THE STORY

I used to think presence meant hours logged — same room, same couch. But I'd be *there* and not there, half on my phone. My son would say “Dad, look!” and I'd miss it.

— THE CODE

Presence isn't hours logged. It's attention given. The bond is built in the small moments you choose to turn toward.

THE RESEARCH, LIGHTLY

Gottman's “**bids for connection**” — relationships are built (or eroded) in tiny everyday moments. “Dad, look!” is a bid. Turning toward it is the whole game.

● ONE THING TODAY

Turn toward three bids today — fully, phone down — for one week. Watch what changes.

The 6-Word Reset

THE STORY

I couldn't be present when I was flooded — jaw tight, fuse short. The reframe that saved me came in six words, said under my breath before I reacted.

— THE CODE

You can't parent well while you're flooded. Regulate *your* storm first — the parenting follows. The six words: “*They're not giving me a hard time — they're having one.*”

THE RESEARCH, LIGHTLY Emotional co-regulation — a calm adult nervous system helps settle a child's. You can't pour calm from a flooded cup.

● ONE THING TODAY

Before you react next time: one slow breath, then the six words. Just once today.

When Your Brain Works Differently

THE STORY

Diagnosed with ADHD at 47, dyslexic my whole life — I spent years sure I was broken. I wasn't. I just needed systems, not shame.

— THE CODE

Neurodivergent dads don't thrive on willpower — they thrive on external systems. Reminders, routines, and self-forgiveness beat white-knuckling it every time.

THE RESEARCH, LIGHTLY For ADHD/dyslexic parents, the real blocker isn't capability — it's **shame**. Outsource memory to systems and the shame loses its grip.

● ONE THING TODAY

Build one “second brain” system for the thing you keep forgetting — a phone alarm, a whiteboard, a sticky note on the door.

Repair Beats Perfect

THE STORY

I snap. I get it wrong. I've raised my voice and watched my kid's face fall. For a long time I thought that made me a bad dad. It doesn't. What I did *next* did.

— THE CODE

You'll get it wrong. What your kids remember is whether you come back. “I got that wrong, mate. I'm sorry.” That's the repair — and it builds more trust than never rupturing at all.

THE RESEARCH, LIGHTLY

Rupture and repair — secure attachment comes from *fixing* the breaks, not avoiding them. The repair is the lesson.

● ONE THING TODAY

Make one real repair this week, out loud. No “but.” Just: “I got that wrong. I'm sorry.”

The Air Cuddle

THE STORY

My son whispers “I love you, Dad,” and we press our ears together — the air cuddle. It costs nothing. It's ours. And it's the thing he'll remember.

— THE CODE

Tiny rituals are how presence becomes permanent. They cost nothing and outlast everything.

THE RESEARCH, LIGHTLY Small, predictable rituals build security and belonging — the everyday repetition matters more than the grand gesture.

● ONE THING TODAY

Create one two-second ritual that's just yours — a handshake, a word, a press of the ears.

CLOSE

Present, Not Perfect

The cycle stops with you.

You don't have to become the dad you never had overnight. You don't have to get it all right. You just have to show up today — imperfectly, honestly, present.

That's the whole code. That's enough.

Keep Going

You finished the book. That's a bid toward yourself — so turn toward it. Here's where to go next.



The podcast — Dad's Code

The real conversations behind these six chapters. New episode every week. Subscribe wherever you listen.



The memoir — *The Frequency of Being Real*

The full story: the grief, the late diagnosis, the rebuild. This field guide is the map; the memoir is the journey.



Do one thing — tonight

Pick a single “One Thing Today” from this book and do it before you sleep. Presence starts with one turn toward.

Present, not perfect. — Jamie

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